

Wink or blink?

Politics of Care as a Feminist Counter-Strategy

How interpretive methods help us see what is behind the picture

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Care in times of crisis



Crisis is everyday life

For many people in the Global South, crisis is not a new event. It is everyday life, getting harder.



A crisis of care

Social reproduction, the work that keeps life going, is most needed in disasters and least supported by public institutions.



People organize to survive

Neighbours cook for each other, collect money, bring medicine, hide someone in danger.

POLITICS OF CARE

Collective practices of mutual aid that keep life going in times of crisis, and that, through the trust they create, become the ground for political action.

The puzzle

Care is often seen as private and politically limited. Can it become the ground on which big political movements stand?

How this research was organized



No separate grant

The research grew out of my postdoctoral fellowship.



IRGAC

International Research Group on Authoritarianism and Counter-Strategies: researchers, many from the Global South, who study authoritarianism and how people resist it.



Collective knowledge

Built through discussions with colleagues, comrades and activists. The line between researcher and participant is not always sharp.

Jin, Jiyan, Azadî

Woman, Life, Freedom

13 Sept 2022

Jina (Mahsa) Amini is arrested by the morality police in Tehran for "improper" hijab.

16 Sept 2022

She dies in hospital. At her funeral in Saqqez, women unveil; protests spread across the country.

What surprised me

1

Scale

Many parts of society, big cities and small towns

2

Demands

Progressive demands and beyond gender equality

3

Form

Performative, in neighbourhoods, not mainly street marches

Yanow: our expectations decide what surprises us. The surprise was where the research began.

The repeated scene



1 Stand on a height



2 Unveil



3 Others support



4 Cut hair or burn the scarf

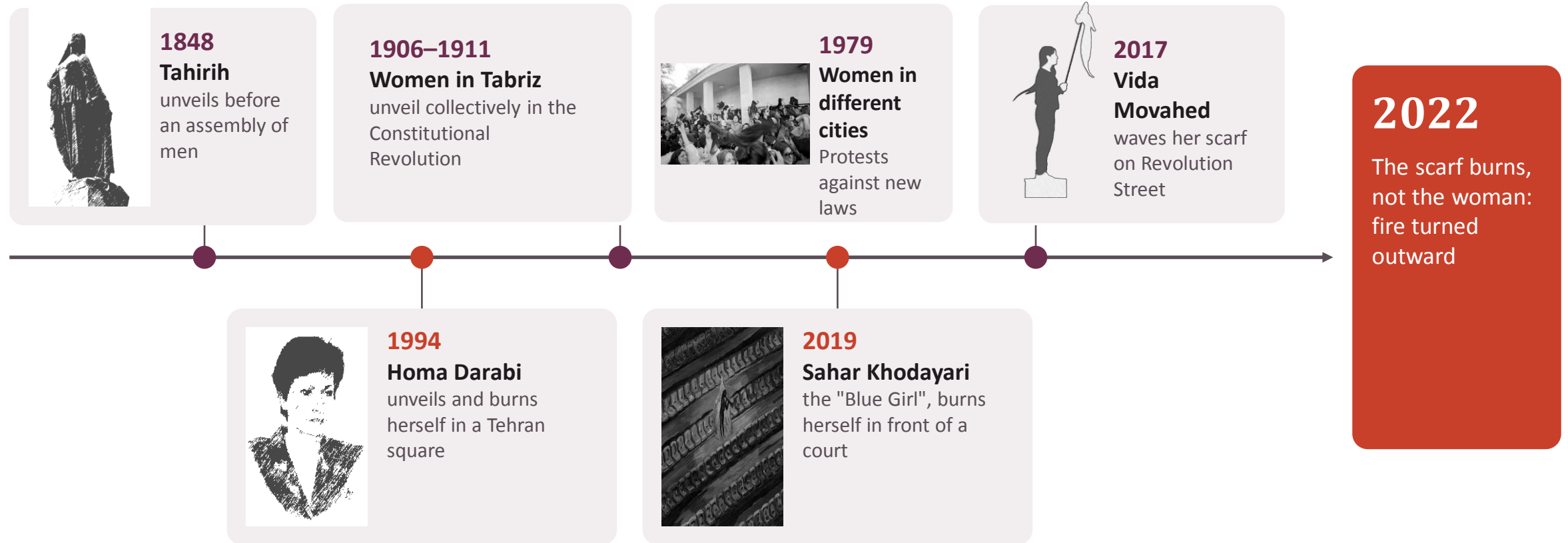


"[Anyone] can create an unbelievable, radical situation of resistance by themselves, such that it astonishes the viewer."

L., feminist writer and protester (2022)

Two histories behind one gesture

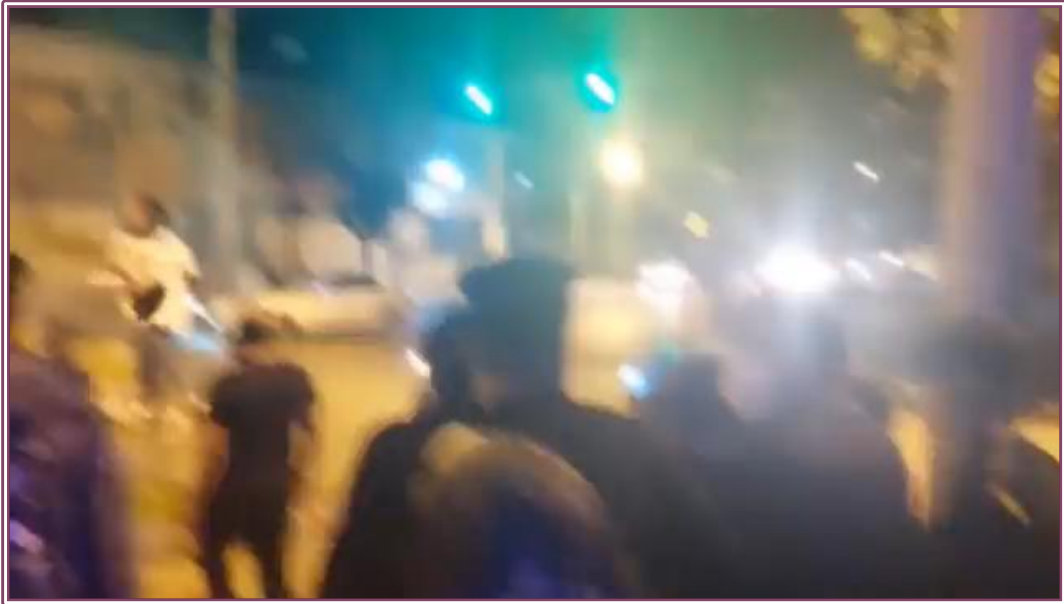
Unveiling as protest



Self-immolation as political protest

On stage, off stage

ON STAGE



OFF STAGE: what happens before and after



Build a barricade



Secure the street



Bring a bin or park a car to climb on



Film and share



Keep watch

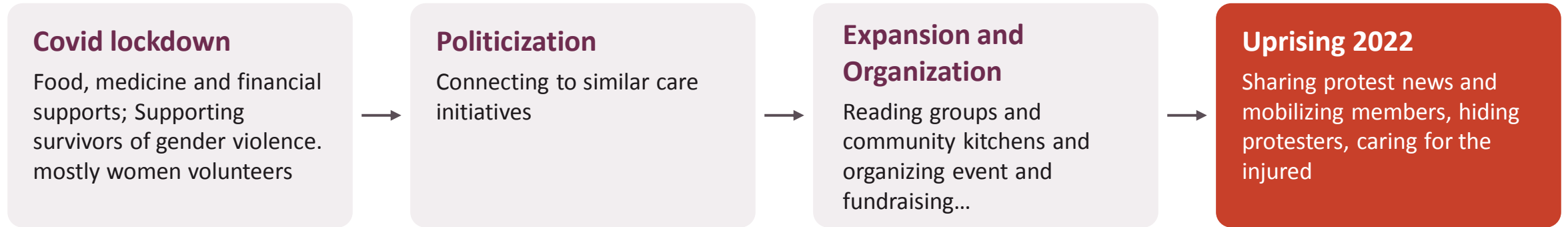


Hide, regroup, next "situation"

Provisional inference (Yanow): this risky teamwork, done in seconds, needs practice and trust between people. Where does that trust come from? Care?

Testing the hunch: where did the trust come from?

Tracing Telegram mutual-aid groups from Covid to the uprising



Triangulation



FINDING

The politics of care was the backbone of the 2022 uprising: feminist not only in its slogans, but in its practice.

Restaurantera Feminista

Why Mexico?

- From Iran to global patterns: India, Kurdistan, Latin America
- Access: existing contacts and an earlier visit
- Three months of fieldwork, based in Mexico City
- Groups active in recent feminist mobilizations, all doing care or reproductive work

2

queer restaurant and bar workers started a #MeToo-style page



Legal advice on harassment



Feminist night marches

1000s

of workers shared their own stories within months



Labour-rights workshops



Alliance with Chicago workers

100+

active members today, with branches across Mexico



Protests at restaurants

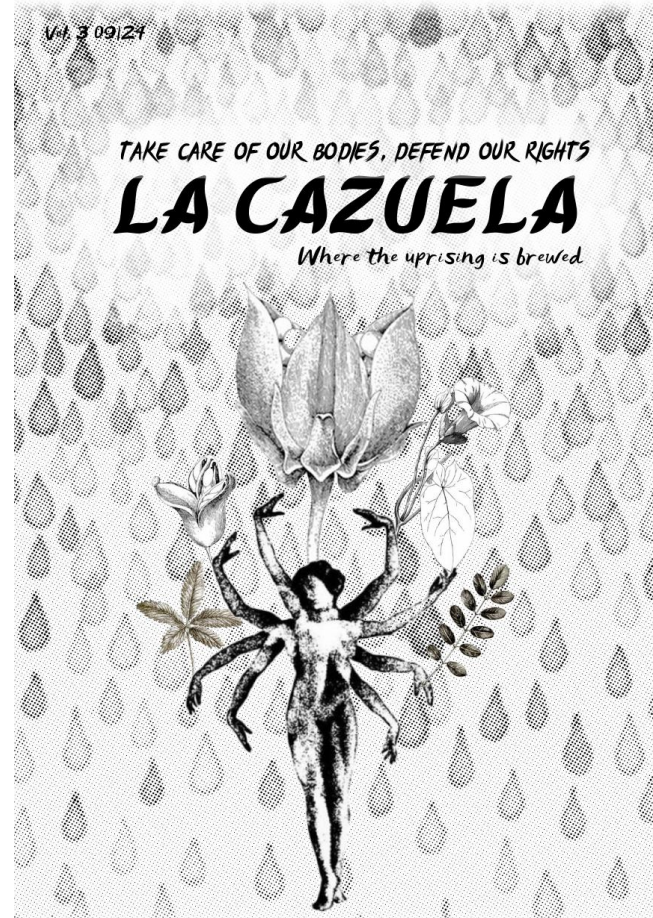


Zine and podcast

What's in a cazuela?



"What's in a Schnitzel?"



"Where the uprising is brewed": the kitchen, a place of invisible care work, becomes the place where revolt is cooked.

"Oído, chef"

A worker swallows her anger to keep a roof over her head (Vol. 1)

"Class consciousness must be feminist"

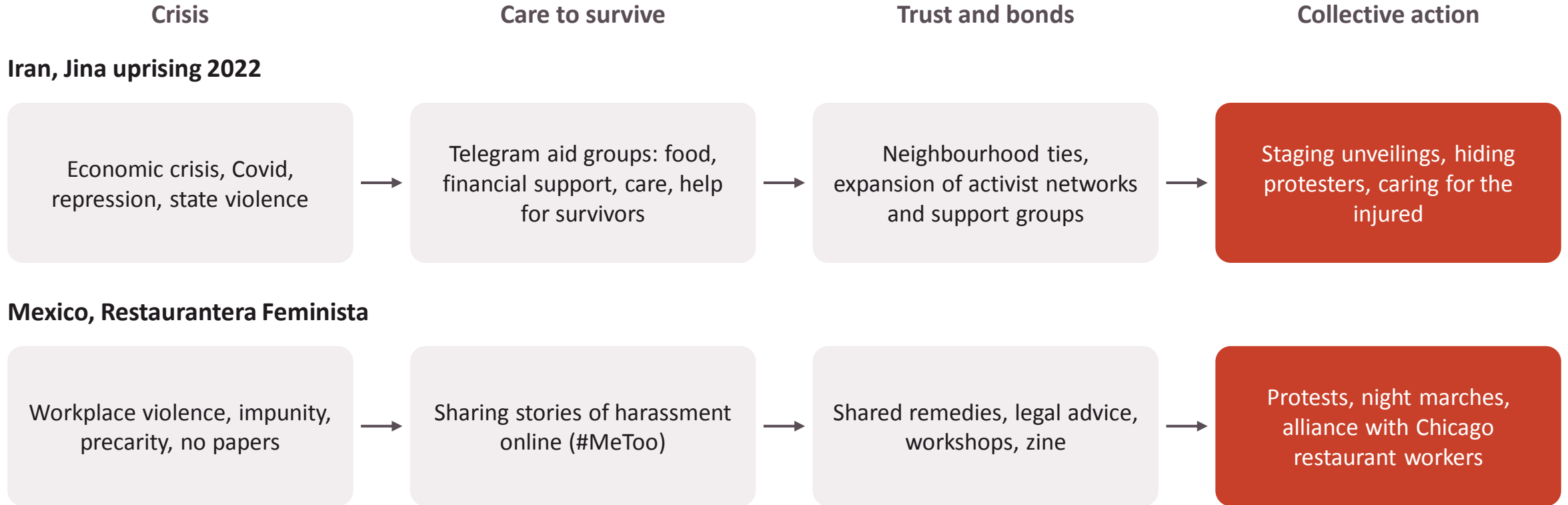
"And who takes care of us?" (Vol. 3)

"Embrace and resist!"

Shared home remedies for bodies worn out by work (Vol. 3)

Survival brought them together: care born of necessity turned into politics.

Care as infrastructure: one mechanism, two contexts



In both, the state is absent or the perpetrator: care fills the gap and turns into politics.

Not a variable-based comparison: two very different regimes, used to sharpen one concept.

What these methods cannot show



Sample

Interviewees came through my own feminist networks, so politicized voices are likely over-represented.



Visibility

I see only what became visible: viral videos, groups that left traces. No counts, no claims about every protest.



Ethics

Everyone anonymized, no faces; in Mexico only what the collective published.



Romanticizing care

Care work is exhausting, often unpaid, and can reproduce inequalities. It is not a magic solution.

TAKEAWAY

Behind every iconic protest image there is hidden meaning and care work, and interpretive methods are how we can see it.

A wink is not a blink, and an unveiling is not just a woman taking off a scarf.

Thank you



Questions for you

1

When you see a viral protest photo, what can it tell you, and what can it not tell you?

2

Could a survey or a count of protest events have found these care networks? Why or why not?

3

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